

Languages from the past

Many languages that were famous twenty or thirty years ago have fallen in popularity, despite still being used in some very important systems. These languages are often seen as difficult to code by modern standards.

BASIC

Designed in 1964 at Dartmouth College, in the US, BASIC was very popular when home computers first became available.

Fortran

Designed in 1954 at IBM, a technology firm, Fortran is mainly used for calculations on large computers. It is still being used in weather forecasting.

COBOL

Designed in 1959 by a committee of experts, COBOL is still being used in many business and banking programs.

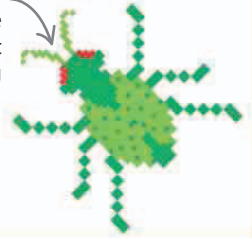


REAL WORLD

Millennium bug

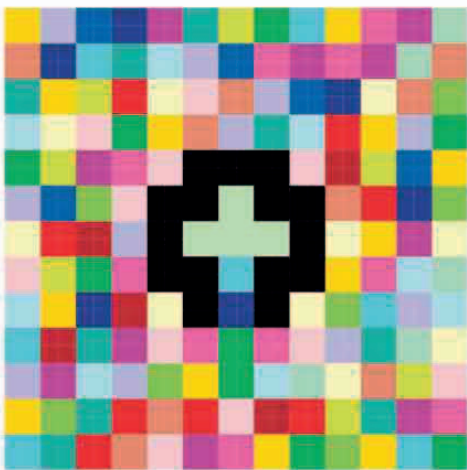
Many programs in older languages like COBOL used two digits to represent a year (such as 99 for 1999). The “millennium bug” was predicted to cause problems in 2000 when these dates rolled over into the new millennium as 00.

Computers all over the world had to be updated to prevent the millennium bug



Weird languages

Among the thousands of languages are a few that have been created for very specific and strange purposes.



△ Piet

Programs created in Piet code look like abstract art. The “Hello World!” program is shown above.

```
('&%:9]!~}}z2Vxwv-,POqponl$Hjig%eB@@>a=<M:9[p6tsl1TS/
QIOj)L(I&%$""Z~AA@UZ=RvttT`R5P3m0LEDh,T*?(b&$#87[]W
```

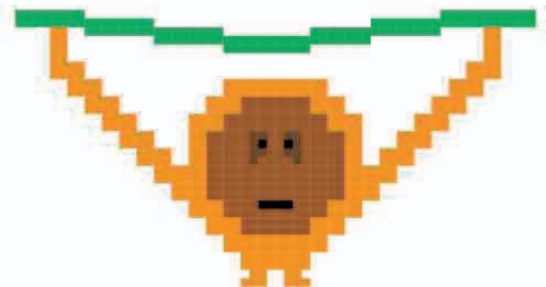
△ Malbolge

The Malbolge language was designed to be impossible to program. The first working code did not emerge until two years after its release, and was written by another program.



△ Chef

A program written in Chef is meant to resemble a cooking recipe. However, in practice, the programs rarely produce useful cooking instructions.



△ Ook!

Designed to be used by orangutans, Ook! has only three elements: “Ook”, “Ook!”, and “Ook?” These can be combined to create six commands, such as “Ook! Ook” and “Ook? Ook!”